Parshas Balak

Doing the Right Thing for the Wrong Reasons

Bilam · Korbanos · Intention · Mah Tovu

I. A Right Action for the Wrong Reason

Parshas Balak is a powerful study in what happens when someone tries to do a right action for entirely wrong reasons, and even more strikingly, when that action was never theirs to do in the first place.

There is a well-known idea, found across Gemara, mussar, Chassidus, and even secular self-help, that doing the right thing for the wrong reason long enough eventually leads to doing it for the right reason. The classic formulation is mitoch shelo lishmah, ba lishmah, from doing something not for its own sake, one eventually comes to do it for its own sake, as the Gemara teaches in Pesachim 50b. But Parshas Balak throws a wrench directly into that formula, because it shows us a case where the action itself was never authentically available to the person performing it.

II. Bilam's Strategy

We meet Bilam, the non-Jewish prophet hired by Balak to curse the Jewish people. And what is Bilam's strategy for getting on Hashem's good side? Korbanos. Sacrifices.

וַיֹּאמֶר בִּלְעָם אֶל בָּלָק בְּנֵה לִי בָזֶה שִׁבְעָה מִזְבְּחֹת

"Bilam said to Balak: Build for me here seven altars."

— Bamidbar 23:1

Bilam knew the history. Avraham, Yitzchak, Yaakov, and the Jewish people had all brought korbanos throughout their history with Hashem. He assumed that offering sacrifices would earn him similar favor. After all, the Torah often describes the korban as a rei'ach nichoach laHashem, a pleasing aroma to Hashem. But as Chazal and Rashi point out, Hashem does not literally smell the sacrifice. He desires the intent behind it. The

rei'ach nichoach is not about the act itself. It is about obedience, connection, and alignment with the Divine will that the act is meant to express.

III. The Gift That Was Never Yours to Give

Rabbi Yehoshua Gordon, zichrono livrachah, once compared korbanos to a husband giving his wife flowers, not because she needs them, but because the gesture represents love and attentiveness already present in the relationship. If a stranger brings those same flowers to someone else's wife, it is not romantic. It is unsettling. The gesture is identical. The relationship behind it is not.

That is exactly what happened with Bilam and Balak. They tried to hijack the ritual of korbanos, not in order to connect with Hashem, but in order to manipulate Him into a desired outcome. They brought a gift that was never theirs to give, attempting to offer it to a God they did not actually serve. And Hashem's response, in effect, is: you want My attention? You have it. But you are not in control of what happens next. Bilam asks for permission to curse, and Hashem allows him to speak, but only what Hashem permits him to say.

IV. An Unwilling Mouthpiece for Blessing

And in a stunning twist, Bilam ends up blessing Am Yisrael with some of the most beautiful words ever spoken about them:

מַה טֹּבוּ אׇהָלֶיךָ יַעֲקֹב

"How good are your tents, O Yaakov."
— Bamidbar 24:5

He praises their tznius, their unity, their moral strength. Instead of destruction, Bilam becomes an unwilling mouthpiece for Divine praise, the exact opposite of what he and Balak set out to accomplish.

V. So Was It the Right Thing in the End?

Did Bilam eventually do the right thing for the right reasons? Not exactly. But Hashem shows us something important here. Even misguided actions can be redirected by Hashem's hand. Even a corrupted ritual can be repurposed for good. And even an enemy, when given a microphone by Hashem, can end up blessing the very thing he set out to destroy.

VI. The Deeper Lesson

Sof maaseh b'machshavah techilah, the final deed is rooted in the original thought, as we say in Lecha Dodi. Our intentions matter deeply. We cannot simply copy the outward action of a mitzvah without the heart behind it and expect the same result. Korbanos, when brought with humility and truth, draw us close to Hashem. But when the same ritual is used manipulatively, it backfires, or worse, exposes the arrogance underneath it.

And still, through it all, Hashem remains in control. That is the greatest comfort in this entire parsha: that even in the face of open hostility, even when someone tries to use holy tools for an unholy purpose, Hashem can turn curses into blessings and corrupted gestures into vehicles for truth.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

- *Am I ever guilty of going through the motions of a mitzvah while my actual intention is somewhere else entirely? What would it take to close that gap?*
- *Is there a gesture or ritual in my life that has become about the outward act rather than the relationship it is meant to express?*
- *Where in my life have I tried to use something holy to get an outcome I wanted, rather than to genuinely connect with Hashem?*
- *Bilam ended up blessing what he tried to curse. Where have I seen Hashem redirect something that started in the wrong place toward an unexpectedly good outcome?*
- *What does mah tovu ohalecha Yaakov mean to me personally? What about my own home or community would I want Hashem to praise?*
- *Sof maaseh b'machshavah techilah: where in my life right now does my original thought need adjusting before the final deed can truly be what I want it to be?*